released in an amnesty in 1955 and went to Mexico where he continued the struggle in exile. Returning to Cuba in December 1956 with just eighty-two armed supporters, his hopes of triggering a popular rising came to naught, and with only a dozen surviving followers, he embarked on a guerrilla war in the Sierra Maestra mountains in south-eastern Cuba.

In February 1957 Castro secured a significant propaganda coup when he was interviewed in the Sierra Maestra by Herbert Matthews of the *New York Times.* The seasoned American journalist told his readers that Castro's ambitions for his people were 'a new deal for Cuba, radical, democratic and therefore anti-Communist.'[12] Matthews described Castro as 'an educated, dedicated fanatic, a man of ideals, of courage and of remarkable qualities of leadership,' who 'has strong ideas of liberty, democracy, social justice, the need to restore the constitution, to hold elections.'[13] Fidel assured Herbert, 'You can be sure we have no animosity toward the United States and the American people.'[14]

On 1 January 1959 General Batista fled Cuba as his army collapsed. A week later Fidel Castro entered Havana in triumph after a 600-mile march across the country. Batista had been in power from 1933 to 1940 and again since 1952. Outside Cuba he was widely recognised as an especially corrupt and brutal dictator. Indeed, in the 1960 election Senator Kennedy described his government as 'one of the most bloody and repressive dictatorships in the long history of Latin American repression,' who had 'murdered twenty thousand Cubans in seven years.'[15] Kennedy also recognised that addressing the economic and social well-being of people in Central and South America was essential to combat the appeal of revolution. That understanding underpinned the Alliance for Progress that the President launched in March 1961. This promised US economic support in expectation that landowners and industrialists would accept land and tax reforms. Such changes did not materialise. In the words of one of Kennedy's biographers, Robert Dallek, the initiative proved 'an exercise in unrealized hopes'.[16]

Understanding Castro's ideas, and the development of his relations with Moscow, preoccupied US officials in the ensuing months and years, as relations between Washington and Havana deteriorated and those between